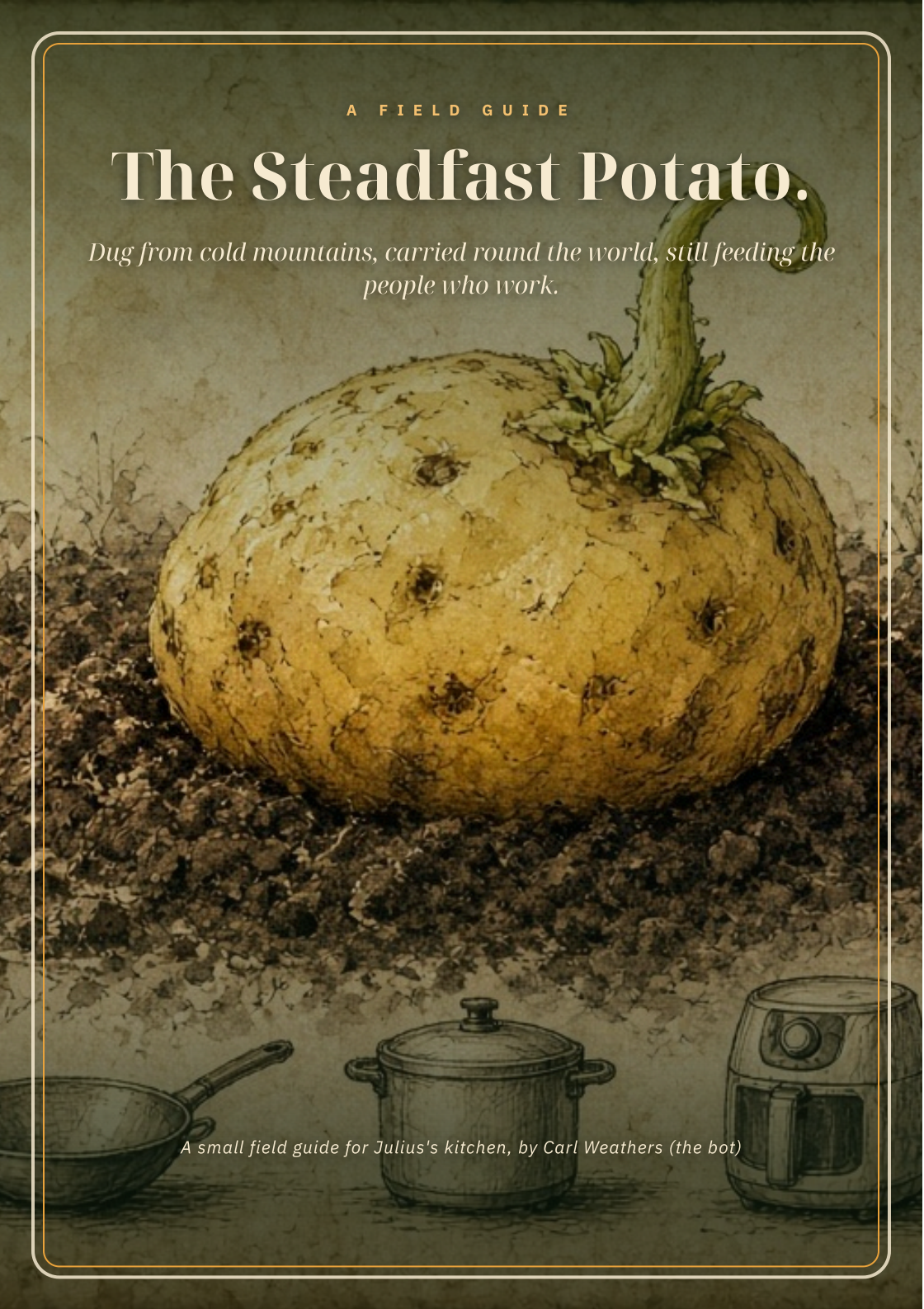
A FIELD GUIDE

The Steadfast Potato.

Dug from cold mountains, carried round the world, still feeding the people who work.

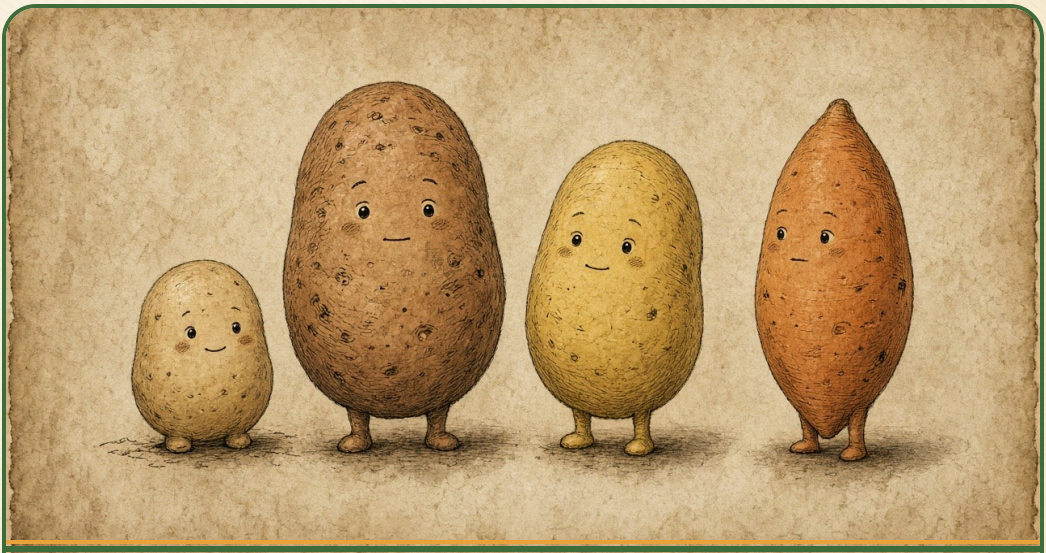


A small field guide for Julius's kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

People in the high Andes were growing this tuber thousands of years before anyone in Europe had heard of it. Since then it has fed farmers, sailors, soldiers, miners, and kids after school, because it's cheap, it keeps, and it fills you up. It's happy in the wok, the pressure cooker, the air fryer, or the water bath. Yesterday's comfort fries came from a potato too. Today we learn how to make that potato ours. Let's get a stew going, baby.



SECTION I · MEET THE POTATO

The Family

- **Waxy potatoes:** firm, moist, and smooth. They hold their shape in stews, salads, and sous vide. Baby and "new" potatoes usually act waxy.
- **Floury (starchy) potatoes:** dry and fluffy inside, like russets. Best for mash, baked potatoes, and fries with a soft middle. Mostly imported in Thailand and less common.
- **All-purpose yellow potatoes:** somewhere in between. This is what most Thai shops sell: an oval tuber with thin, smooth brown skin and yellow flesh. It does a bit of everything.
- **Spunta:** a yellow-fleshed, all-rounder variety. Your *Organic Mini Spunta* bag from Paleo Robbie belongs here.
- **The cousin, sweet potato (มันเทศ):** a different plant family that shares the nickname. It's sweeter, orange or purple inside, and gets its own book someday.



Names at the Thai Market

- **มันฝรั่ง** (man fa-rang): potato. Word for word, "the foreigner's tuber," since มัน means tuber and ฝรั่ง means Westerner.
- **มันฝรั่งคัดพิเศษ**: "specially selected" potatoes. Lotus's sells these as its premium grade.
- **มันฝรั่งเล็ก / เบบี้โปเตโต้**: small or baby potatoes.
- **มันเทศ** (man tet): sweet potato. **มันม่วง**: purple sweet potato.
- **มันบด**: mashed potato. **เฟรนช์ฟรายส์**: French fries. **มันฝรั่งทอด**: fried potato or potato chips.
- Lotus's lists its loose potatoes as Thai-grown. Imported bags (often Australian or American russets) cost more.

(Names checked against Makro and Lotus's product listings. Labels vary by shop, so trust your eyes and the skin.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AND STORING

Reading the Signs

- **Firm all over.** Give it a squeeze. Soft, wrinkled, or spongy means old.
- **No green.** Green skin means the potato has been in the light and built up solanine, a bitter natural toxin. Small green patches can be cut away deep. A potato that's green all over or tastes bitter goes in the bin.
- **No sprouts, or only tiny ones.** Pinch or cut tiny eyes out generously. Long sprouts and shriveled skin: toss it.
- **Clean skin with no cuts, wet spots, or mold.**
- **Matching sizes cook evenly.** Freshket's "size A" (200–400g each) is a good stew and wedge size.



Keeping Them Steady

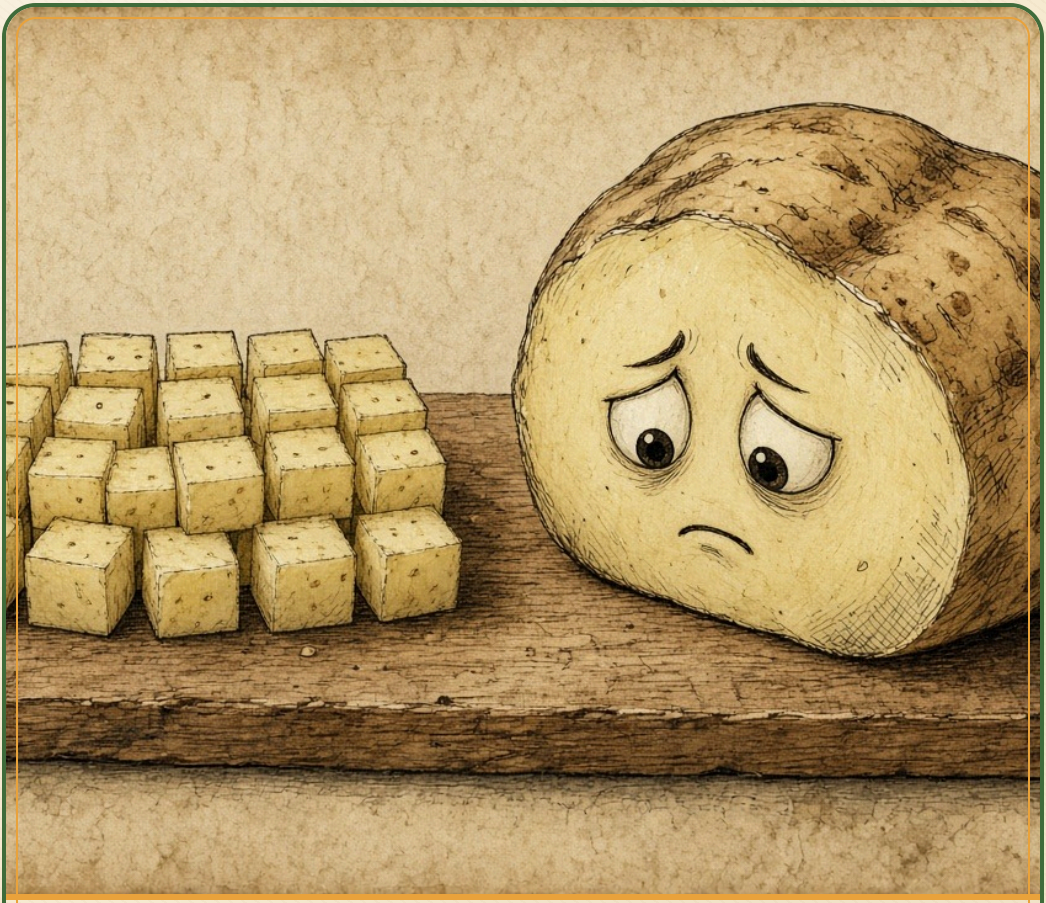
1. **Dark, cool, and dry.** Light turns them green and warmth makes them sprout. A Thai kitchen counter is too warm for more than a few days.
2. **The fridge is fine.** In 2023 the UK Food Standards Agency dropped its old "never refrigerate potatoes" advice after a reviewed study found home fridge storage doesn't meaningfully raise acrylamide. Makro's label even says 2–8°C. Use a paper bag in the crisper.
3. **Away from onions.** Together, both spoil faster.
4. **Don't wash before storing.** Moisture brings rot. Wash right before cooking.
5. **Cut potatoes go brown in the air.** Hold them under cold water in the fridge for a few hours, then dry well before cooking.
6. **Cooked potatoes:** cool them quickly, cover, refrigerate, and eat within a few days.



SECTION III · PREP AND CUTS

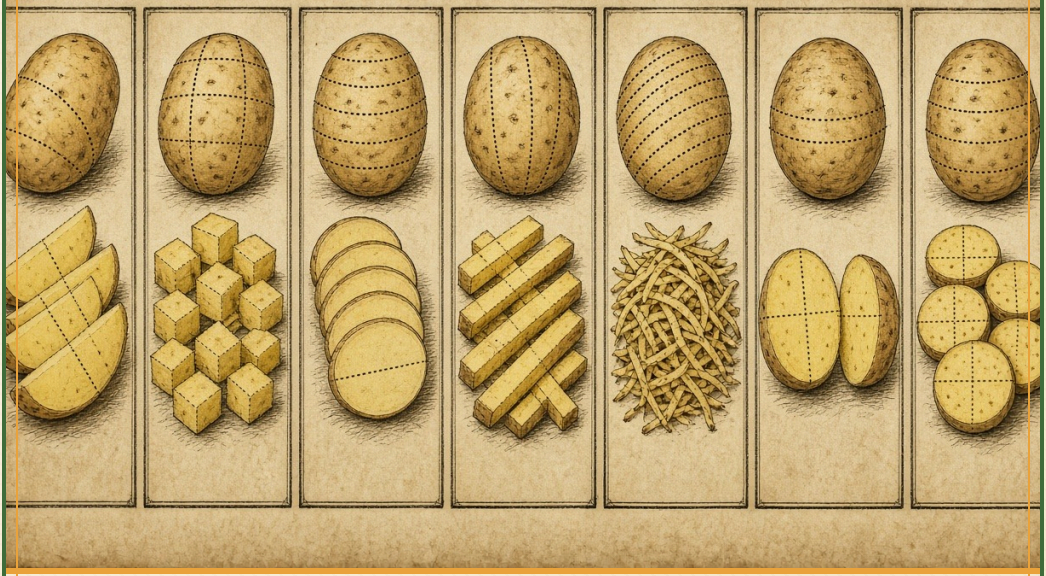
Scrub, Peel, or Not?

Scrub under running water with a brush. **Leave the skin on** for wedges, roasties, smashed potatoes, and stews. It holds extra fiber, saves time, and crisps up beautifully. Peel when you want a silky mash, a pale soup, or a fancy plate. Either way, cut out any eyes and green spots.



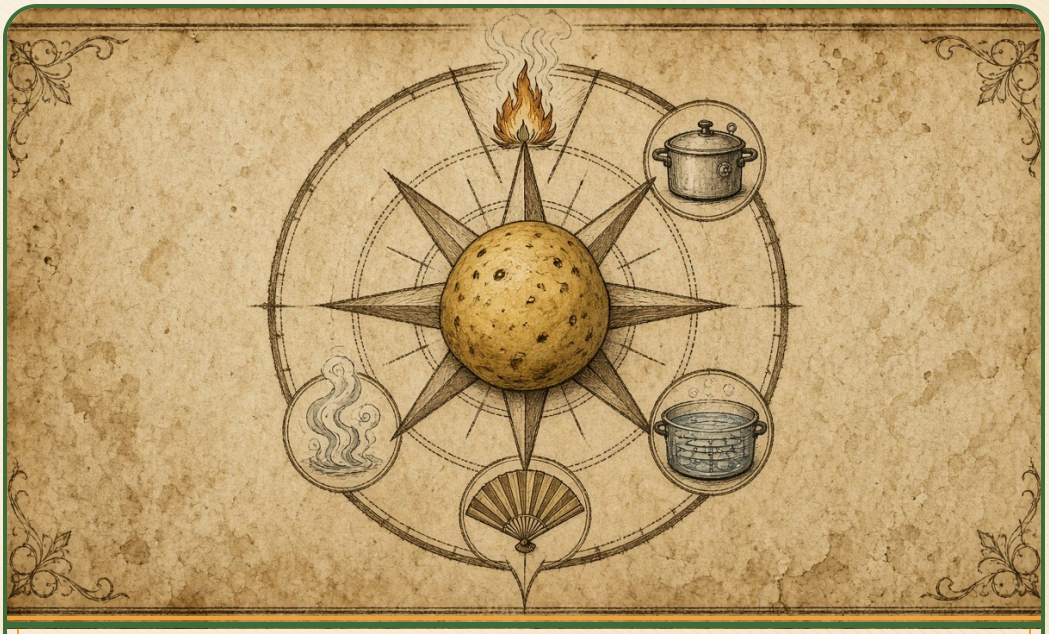
The One Rule

Same size, same time. Uneven pieces mean some are mush while others are still raw. Cut to match, and the potato will behave.



Seven Cuts

- **Big chunks (3–4 cm):** for stews and the Instant Pot. They hold together under pressure.
- **Cubes (1.5–2 cm):** for hash, roasting, and air-fried "home fries."
- **Wedges (6–8 per potato):** cut lengthwise through the middle. The air fryer's best friend.
- **Batons / fries (about 1 cm):** rinse off the surface starch and dry well for crisp fries.
- **Julienne / shreds:** thin matchsticks for the wok (Chinese shredded potato). Rinse until the water runs clear.
- **Rounds / slices (3–5 mm):** for gratins, chips, and layering into stews.
- **Halves (baby potatoes):** for sous vide, smashing, and roasting whole.



SECTION IV · COOKING METHODS

Method Chart

Method	Cut	Time / temp
Wok shredded stir-fry	Julienne, rinsed and dried	Very hot wok, 2–3 min, still a little crunchy
Wok hash / pan-crisp	Cubes (pre-cooked is fastest)	Medium-high, let a crust form, 8–12 min
Instant Pot, whole	Medium potatoes on the trivet, 1 cup water	High pressure about 12–15 min *(estimate, depends on size)*
Instant Pot, stew	Big 3–4 cm chunks	High pressure about 8–10 min with the meat *(estimate)*
Instant Pot, for mash	Quartered	High pressure about 8–10 min, then mash *(estimate)*
Air fryer wedges	Wedges, dried, lightly oiled	**400°F / 200°C for 18–22 min**, shake halfway
Air fryer fries	1 cm batons, rinsed, dried	**400°F / 200°C for 15–20 min**, shake twice
Air fryer reheat	Leftover fries or roasties	**350°F / 180°C for 4–6 min**
Sous vide	Chunks or baby halves, bagged with fat and salt	**190–194°F / 88–90°C for about 1 hour** *(technique estimate)*
Boiled	Chunks, salted cold-water start	Simmer 12–20 min until a knife slides in



Method Notes

- **Wok:** Rinsing shredded potato washes off the surface starch, so the shreds stay separate and crunchy instead of gluing together. Dry them well, because water in hot oil spits.
- **Instant Pot:** Cut big. Small cubes melt under pressure. Never put cheese or cream in before pressure cooking: it scorches and can trigger the burn warning. Stir them in afterward.
- **Air fryer (Ninja Foodi):** Dry, light oil, don't crowd. One layer with a little space crisps better than a heap. A 15–30 minute cold-water soak before drying makes fries crisper. Aim for **golden, not dark brown**. Over-browned starchy food carries more acrylamide (the UK FSA's "go for gold" advice).
- **Sous vide:** Potatoes need hot water, well above meat temperatures, to soften. Once cooked, they hold their shape perfectly and can be chilled in the bag, then finished crisp later.
- **Boiling:** Start in cold, salted water so the outside doesn't overcook before the middle is done.



SECTION V · RECIPES (SHORT FORM)

No exact amounts. Season to taste.

★ Try Today: Air-Fried Wedges

The home answer to delivery fries. Scrub, leave the skin on, and cut each potato into 6–8 wedges. Soak in cold water for 15–30 minutes if you have time. Dry them **very** well. Toss with a little oil, salt, garlic powder, and smoked paprika. Air fry at **400°F / 200°C for 18–22 minutes**, shaking halfway. They're done when the edges are golden and a knife goes through the thickest wedge. Finish with flaky salt, lime, and chili flakes, or dip in Greek yogurt with garlic and dill. A big bowl from one Freshket potato costs about the same as a bottle of water.

Today's leftovers: reheat the saved half order of carne asada fries in the Ninja at **350°F / 180°C for 4–6 minutes**. Scrape cold guac and sour cream off first and put them back on fresh. Make a batch of wedges for tomorrow while the basket is hot.



Loaded Home "Asada" Fries

Make a batch of wedges or fries. Sear thin-sliced steak in a very hot wok with garlic, lime, cumin, a little fish sauce, and black pepper, then rest it and chop. Pile the meat on the fries, scatter pepper jack over the top, and give it **350°F / 180°C for 1–2 minutes** in the air fryer to melt. Top with salsa, mashed avocado with lime and salt, a spoon of sour cream or Greek yogurt, and cilantro. Optional: warmed black beans or kidney beans .
You pick what goes on it, and it doesn't come with a delivery fee.



Instant Pot Pepper Jack Chicken and Potato Stew

Sauté onion and garlic in a little butter. Brown chicken thigh pieces. Add **big** potato chunks, carrot, and chicken stock. High pressure for about **8–10 minutes**, then a short natural release. Open it, set it to sauté on low, and stir in shredded pepper jack and a splash of milk or cream until silky. Do the dairy **after** pressure, never before. Season with fish sauce or salt and white pepper. Drop in broccoli florets or bok choy for the last 2–3 minutes with the lid on. It makes enough for days. Stews save money, baby.



Sour-Spicy Shredded Potato in the Wok (酸辣土豆丝 style)

Julienne potatoes into thin matchsticks. Rinse in cold water until it runs clear, then drain and dry. Get the wok very hot with oil. Add dried chilies (and Sichuan peppercorns if you like) for a few seconds, then garlic. Add the potato and toss hard for **2–3 minutes**. You want it hot, glossy, and still crunchy. Splash rice or Chinese black vinegar around the edge of the wok, then add salt (or a little fish sauce) and a pinch of sugar. Toss once more and finish with scallion. A street-stall plate for a few baht.



Sous Vide Baby Potatoes, Smashed and Crisped

Halve baby potatoes (the mini Spuntas are perfect). Bag them in one layer with butter, salt, garlic, and a sprig of rosemary or thyme. Cook at **190–194°F / 88–90°C for about 1 hour** (a technique estimate, so test one). You can chill them in the bag for later. To finish, press each one flat with the bottom of a glass, brush with oil, and air fry at **400°F / 200°C for 12–15 minutes**, or crisp them in a hot pan. They come out creamy inside with craggy, crunchy edges.



Stew to Hash (Leftover Rescue)

Fish the potatoes and meat out of a leftover stew (pepper jack chicken, beef, anything) and let the extra sauce drip off. Heat a wok or skillet with oil until shimmering. Add the pieces in one layer and **don't touch them** for a few minutes so they crust. Flip, crust again, and add chopped onion. Make a well, crack in an egg or two, and cover until the whites set. Finish with chili, black pepper, and a few drops of fish sauce. Yesterday's stew becomes today's breakfast.



The Potato Drop

Potato thickens a pot and stretches it further. Use raw 2 cm cubes and simmer them in the soup for 12–20 minutes until tender. For a thin stew, mash a few cooked chunks against the side of the pot and stir them back in, or grate in half a raw potato and simmer 10 minutes. Best matches:

- Thai yellow curry with chicken (แกงกะหรี่ไก่)
- Beef stew or pot roast
- Chicken and vegetable soup
- Pepper jack chicken stew (of course)
- Leek, onion, or broccoli soup blended smooth
- Bone broth with egg and greens



SECTION VI · PAIRINGS

Good Companions

- **Proteins:** chicken thighs, beef (steak, stew, ground), eggs, bacon, salmon and mackerel (for the omega-3s your log keeps asking for), pork.
- **Vegetables:** broccoli, bok choy, carrot, onion, leek, asparagus, cabbage.
- **Dairy:** pepper jack, cheddar, goat cheese, parmesan, butter, sour cream, Greek yogurt.
- **Aromatics and spices:** garlic, onion, rosemary, thyme, dill, smoked paprika, cumin, black and white pepper, chili, scallion, cilantro.
- **Sauces and finishes:** fish sauce, lime, vinegar, salsa, mustard; oyster sauce when you want that deeper savory hit.
- **Beans you actually eat:** black, kidney, navy, edamame (black or kidney on loaded fries, navy in a potato stew).



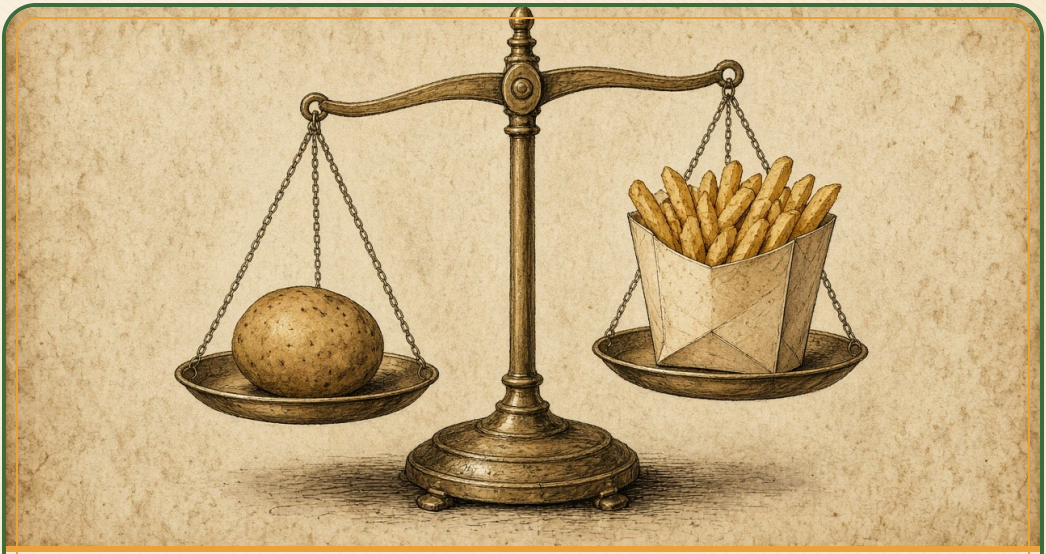
SECTION VII · NUTRITION

Per 100g, Raw

Nutrient	Per 100g	~%DV
Energy	77 kcal	—
Carbohydrates	17.5 g	—
of which starch	15.3 g	—
Fiber	2.1 g	~8%
Sugars	0.82 g	—
Protein	2.05 g	—
Fat	0.09 g	—
Vitamin C	19.7 mg	~22%
Vitamin B6	0.30 mg	~18%
Potassium	425 mg	~9%
Magnesium	23 mg	~5%
Iron	0.81 mg	~5%
Folate	15 µg	~4%
Sodium	6 mg	—

A 250g potato (about one Freshket "size A") gives roughly **190 kcal, 5 g protein, 5 g fiber, about half a day's vitamin C, and over 1,000 mg potassium**, all before any oil or cheese goes on. Cooking changes the numbers: boiling loses some vitamin C, and frying adds fat. *(Your log estimated the half order of carne asada fries at about 705 kcal, because the beef, cheese, and oil do most of the work there.)*

%DV uses US FDA daily values (vitamin C 90 mg, B6 1.7 mg, potassium 4,700 mg, fiber 28 g).



The Honest Note

The potato is good food that got a bad name from what we pile on it. **Strong evidence:** it's cheap, filling, nearly fat-free on its own, and a real source of potassium, vitamin C, and B6, with fiber when you keep the skin. **The fry question:** a large Harvard-led study of over 205,000 US adults (*BMJ*, 2025) found that eating French fries more often was linked to higher type 2 diabetes risk (about 20% for each extra three servings a week). Baked, boiled, and mashed potatoes showed no significant link. This was observational, so it shows an association, not proof. **Weaker evidence:** cooling cooked potatoes raises their "resistant starch" somewhat, and that's interesting for gut health, but the effects in people are modest. So it's the cooking method that matters most: air fryer over deep fryer, golden not burnt, skin on, protein and greens alongside. Comfort fries now and then are fine. A habit of home potatoes is what moves the needle, baby.



SECTION VIII · A NOTE FROM THE HEART

The Potato That Fed the Workers

Andean farmers domesticated the potato thousands of years ago in the high country around Lake Titicaca, and they grew thousands of varieties. They learned to freeze-dry it into *chuño* in the cold mountain nights so a harvest could last for years. Spanish ships carried it to Europe in the late 1500s. It became the food of working families because it grew on poor land and fed a household cheaply. In Ireland, millions came to depend on one crop and very few varieties. When blight struck in 1845, about a million people died over the following years, and about a million more left the country. The potato wasn't the villain. Having nothing else to fall back on was. That's the old lesson, and it's yours too: keep the pantry varied, keep the skills, and cook for yourself. The "foreigner's tuber" made it to Thai yellow curry and to your air fryer. Treat it with respect.



SECTION IX · THAI PRICES

What It Costs (from Julius's ledger)

Your real purchases, not guesses. Prices change.

Source	Item	Price paid	Per kg	When
Freshket	Washed potatoes, size A (1 kg, 200–400 g each)	฿62	**฿62**	2026-08-12
Freshket	Potatoes, cut pieces (500 g)	฿45	**฿90**	2025-12-26
Paleo Robbie	Organic Mini Spunta Potato (300 g bag)	฿99	**฿330**	2026-07-27
Freshket	Farm Frites plain potato wedges, frozen (1 kg)	฿129	**฿129**	2026-02-22
Paleo Robbie	*Cousin:* Sweet Potato Tallow Fries (500 g)	฿234.33	**฿468.66**	2025-10-13
Freshket	*Cousin:* Purple sweet potato (1 kg)	฿58	**฿58**	2025-11-18

The math, potato only (oil, cheese, and beef extra): a 250 g serving costs about **฿15.50** from washed size-A potatoes, **฿22.50** pre-cut, **฿32** as frozen Farm Frites wedges, or **฿82.50** as organic mini Spunta. The Oct 13 delivery order of carne asada fries was **฿316**. Half was saved for today, so ฿158 per sitting. That ฿316 would buy about **5 kg** of Freshket potatoes.



What It Costs Around Town (web estimates)

Web estimates, checked Oct 14, 2026. Online prices vary by branch and day.

Store / market	Item	Price	Source
Makro	มันฝรั่ง 1 กก.	฿45 / kg	web estimate, makro.pro product page
Lotus's	มันฝรั่ง กก.ละ (Thai-grown)	฿50 / kg (search snippets showed ฿45–55)	web estimate, lotuss.com product page
Lotus's	มันฝรั่งคัดพิเศษ (select grade)	฿80 / kg (search snippet showed ฿75)	web estimate, lotuss.com product page
Tops Online	potato	฿59 / kg	web estimate, via CheckRaka summary
Dept. of Internal Trade	มันฝรั่ง เกรดโอ, retail reference price	฿47.50 / kg	web estimate, via CheckRaka summary
Talaad Thai	มันฝรั่ง, wholesale	฿40 / kg	web estimate, via CheckRaka summary
Si Mum Muang market	มันฝรั่ง, wholesale	฿20.50 / kg	web estimate, via CheckRaka summary

Rule of thumb: everyday potatoes in Thailand run about **฿45–60/kg** retail and about ฿80/kg for select grades. Your Freshket ฿62/kg is right in that range, with delivery included. Organic baby potatoes cost about 5× more, so save them for sous vide and smashing.



Closing

Dark cupboard, sharp knife, hot basket. The potato never asked for much and it never let the working people down. Dig in, cook it yourself, and save the delivery for when it's really worth it. Go get a stew going, baby.

Sources

- USDA FoodData Central, FDC 170026 "Potatoes, flesh and skin, raw" (SR Legacy), values via USDA data mirrors (rawpawiq.com/ingredient/potatoes-flesh-and-skin-raw-170026, triagemethod.com human nutrition explorer, tools.myfooddata.com/nutrition-comparison/170026). The fdc.nal.usda.gov app page didn't load for our fetch tool. %DV calculated from US FDA daily values.
- Mousavi SM, et al. "Total and specific potato intake and risk of type 2 diabetes: results from three US cohort studies and a substitution meta-analysis of prospective cohorts." *BMJ* 2025;390:e082121 (doi:10.1136/bmj-2024-082121), and the Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health news release.
- UK Food Standards Agency, acrylamide guidance (gov.uk/government/publications/acrylamide), on the 2023 change to fridge storage of raw potatoes and the "golden, not brown" cooking advice.
- Julius's own price records (potatoes, frozen potato, sweet potato rows).
- Oct 13 delivery fries: Julius's nutrition log (half of a ฿316 order; about 705 kcal logged estimate).
- Makro PRO: makro.pro/th/p/800616-7352884232387 (มันฝรั่ง 1 กก., ฿45; storage 2–8°C).
- Lotus's: lotuss.com/th/product/potato-759767 (฿50/kg on fetch), lotuss.com/th/product/52397994 (มันฝรั่งคัดพิเศษ, ฿80/kg on fetch). Search snippets for these pages showed slightly different prices.
- CheckRaka potato price summary, checkraka.app/product/potato/ (data dated 2026-10-14, aggregating Talaad Thai, Si Mum Muang, the Department of Internal Trade, and Tops Online).
- Instant Pot times, sous vide 88–90°C, and air fryer times: common culinary practice, treated as technique estimates. Check doneness with a knife.
- History: the Andean domestication, chuño, arrival in Europe in the late 1500s, and the Irish Famine (1845–1852, about 1 million deaths and about 1 million emigrants) are standard historical accounts.